

Down with forgery!

Every now and again I am handed a question that starts out by irritating me, but after I calm down I perceive that God is nudging me to clarify a point that needs it. This happened a while ago with the ‘jewel’ attributed to Jerome that in his day ‘most’ or ‘almost all’ of the Greek manuscripts did not have the last twelve verses of Mark. Since of the 1700 or so Greek MSS known to us that contain the last chapter of Mark only three do not have them (one of them being a falsification at this point), how could a vast majority in the 5th century be reduced to a small fraction of one percent later on? In terms of the science of statistical probability, such an inversion is simply impossible. Only a worldwide campaign that was virtually 100% successful could bring about such a switch, and there is not a shred of evidence for such a campaign. Recall that Diocletian’s campaign to destroy NT MSS (applied unevenly in different areas) was past history by a century (not to mention Constantine’s ‘conversion’ and the consequences thereof). Kenneth Scott Latourette (*A History of Christianity* [New York: Harper, 1953], p. 231) describes Eusebius Hieronimus Sophronius (alias Jerome) as “a gifted and diligent scholar, enormously erudite, a master of languages, a lover of books, wielding a facile, vigorous, and often vitriolic pen” who “was an eloquent advocate of the monastic life”. He doubtless had his defects [don’t we all], but he was not ridiculously stupid, as he would have had to be to make the statement attributed to him. Our knowledge of the ‘jewel’ comes from the tenth century [the interval of five centuries does not inspire confidence]; it is almost certainly a forgery (someone ‘borrowing’ a famous name to give credence to some statement). Since ‘sacred cows’ do not like to die, a review of some relevant history is in order.

K. Aland on Egypt

Even that great champion of an Egyptian text, Kurt Aland, recognized that during the early centuries, including the 4th, Asia Minor (especially the Aegean area) was “the heartland of the Church”. (It also became the heartland of the Byzantine Empire and the Orthodox Churches.) The demand for copies of the NT would have a direct bearing on the supply, and on the areas where copies would be concentrated. But on the subject of Egypt, Aland had this to say:

Our knowledge of the church in Egypt begins at the close of the 2nd century with bishop Demetrius who reorganized the dominantly Gnostic Egyptian church by founding new communities, consecrating bishops, and above all by establishing relationships with the other provinces of the church fellowship.